

Paradigm

In science and philosophy, a **paradigm** (/ˈpərədaɪm/) is a distinct set of concepts or thought patterns, including theories, research methods, postulates, and standards for what constitutes legitimate contributions to a field.

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Etymology

Paradigm comes from Greek παράδειγμα (*paradeigma*), "pattern, example, sample"^[1] from the verb παραδείκνυμι (*paradeiknumi*), "exhibit, represent, expose"^[2] and that from παρά (*para*), "beside, beyond"^[3] and δείκνυμι (*deiknumi*), "to show, to point out".^[4]

In rhetoric, the purpose of paradeigma is to provide an audience with an illustration of similar occurrences. This illustration is not meant to take the audience to a conclusion, however it is used to help guide them there.

One way of how a *paradeigma* is meant to guide an audience would be a personal accountant. It is not the job of a personal accountant to tell their client exactly what (and what not) to spend their money on, but to aid in guiding their client as to how money should be spent based on their financial goals. Anaximenes defined *paradeigma* as "actions that have occurred previously and are similar to, or the opposite of, those which we are now discussing."^[5]

The original Greek term παράδειγμα (*paradeigma*) was used in Greek texts such as Plato's *Timaeus* (28A) as the model or the pattern that the demiurge used to create the cosmos. The term had a technical meaning in the field of grammar: the 1900 *Merriam-Webster* dictionary defines its technical use only in the context of grammar or, in rhetoric, as a term for an illustrative parable or fable. In linguistics, Ferdinand de Saussure used *paradigm* to refer to a class of elements with similarities.